

Five Evenings at the Table

Before we stand up: reading, given circumstances, character and scene work for Six Characters in Search of an Author · Village Players, Lausanne · dir. Kiarash Jamshidi

Thursdays 2 · 9 · 16 · 23 · 30 July 2026 · 18:00–21:00 · SSA Lausanne

Table work is the round of seated readings that comes before any bodies move — the company, the director, the AD and the SM sitting together to build one shared, concrete world out of the text before staging interprets it. Its purpose is not to perform the play but to discover it: to agree the facts, to surface the questions, to name what each scene is really about, and to do enough of this that the August floor work has a spine to build on — and no more, because, as Stanislavski concluded late in his career after decades of work at the Moscow Art Theatre, too much seated analysis traps actors in their heads and divorces thinking from doing. He came to distrust long table rehearsal precisely for opening a gap between the actor's mental and physical work — "the best analysis of a play is to take action in the given circumstances." So these five July evenings are deliberately tight: we read to discover, not to perform, and we get up the moment talk stops earning its keep. The August staging block (20 Aug–1 Nov) is where bodies start to move.

This is a director's edition of Pirandello's "Six Characters in Search of an Author" for the Village Players, a semi-amateur English-language company in Lausanne, sized at nine live performers — the four family, the Manager, three Players, and Madame Pace carried by her own dedicated performer (one of the nine, no longer doubled by a Player). The play sets a specific trap that the table work exists to disarm. Played as farce, the Step-Daughter's near-prostitution, the child's drowning and the Boy's suicide land as gags; played as cold philosophy, the Characters' anguish goes flat and the audience watches an essay. The correct register is Pirandello's own umorismo. In *L'Umorismo* (1908) he splits the idea in two: the merely comic is the *avvertimento del contrario* — the bare perception of the opposite, where you just laugh; umorismo proper is the *sentimento del contrario* — the feeling of the opposite, which arises only when reflection intervenes and turns the laugh bitter. The directorial key is to make the laugh curdle: the company earns the *avvertimento* (you laugh at Madame Pace's accent, at the Manager's vanity) and then, a breath later, reflection drops the floor out and the same beat becomes the *sentimento* (you regret laughing). Get the register wrong and the whole production fails its subject. Concretely that means the company must learn, out loud and before staging, which layer of the play's nested fictions each performer inhabits and what that asks of them.

The shape of the five evenings. The block runs across FIVE Thursday evenings — 2, 9, 16, 23 and 30 July 2026, 18:00–21:00 at SSA Lausanne, everyone seated throughout — in a deliberate arc: three acts in order, then integrate, then a cued read. Sessions 1, 2 and 3 take the acts in turn at the table — Act One (the family arrives, "Valentine," and the bargain) on 2 July, Act Two (the casting, the failure of representation, Madame Pace's apparition, the shower monologue and the keystone) on 9 July, Act Three (the philosophy duel, the Son's refusal and mirror-speech, the fountain and the two deaths) on 16 July — and each of these three act-sessions OPENS its work with the two-pass read of that act's SPINE SCENES (a selected span, not the whole act) before any analysis; the whole-act exposure is held for Session 5's cued read. Session 1 still opens the whole round first, before any charged material: the company's own Room & Safety Agreement (the time-out word, check-in, de-role) and a compressed concept / orders-of-reality frame, THEN the two-pass read of the Act One spine. Session 4 (23 July) works the WHOLE PLAY integrated — relationships across the arc, the metatheatrical orders of reality applied throughout, tempo-rhythm, the nervous comedy, and the charged-scene safety frameworks confirmed in words only, never staged. Session 5 (30

July) runs a full integrated CUED READ of the whole play (cues called by the SM, the pianist marking tempo) and hands off cleanly to the 20 August staging block.

A note on the calendar. The edition's master schedule defines a SEVEN-Thursday table-work block (18 June, 25 June, then 2/9/16/23/30 July), with a first full read on 18 June, a production walk-through on 25 June, and 23 July as a Light & Sound walk-through. This plan deliberately compresses that into the FIVE July Thursdays and adapts the assignments — we say so rather than over-claim calendar fidelity. The dropped 18 June (first full read) and 25 June (production walk-through) material is folded into Session 1: the whole-play orientation lives in Session 1's opening frame and the concept/objects walk-through is given there, with the two stage objects taken up from 2 July. Session 4 deliberately substitutes the edition's 23 July L&S walk-through with integrated, words-only table work, and the cue list is instead walked end-to-end in Session 5's cued read. Where the 16 July note loosely says the Father is "on his feet for the first time," this plan keeps that evening strictly seated, following the block's governing rule — "table work, not blocking" (line 1803), echoed by the protocol's "seven Thursdays are table work only" (build_intimacy_protocol.py line 179) — over the looser phrasing; August is when bodies move.

The signature technique — the two-pass read. Each act-session opens its work with two opposite reads of that act's SPINE SCENES (not the full act — see the timing note in the principle). FIRST a neutral / no-emotion / mechanical pass (flat, throwaway — just the words, the punctuation, the facts; no acting, no line-readings), which surfaces structure, sense and the given circumstances and stops actors locking premature line-readings. THEN a deliberately exaggerated / over-the-top pass (push every emotion to the extreme, play it too big, melodrama), which finds the emotional ceiling, breaks inhibition, and locates exactly where the comedy, danger and real feeling live. A structured debrief follows each pass; the truthful middle is then found later, on the floor, in August. This is a verified composite of established practices — Mitchell's neutral, fact-first table-work; the well-attested anti-line-reading principle (Donnellan, Stareable, No Film School); exaggeration-to-find-range and its failure mode, result-acting (StageMilk, Casting Networks); and the whole arc resting on Stanislavski/Knebel's Active Analysis ("the best analysis is action in the given circumstances") — and we name it honestly as a composite, not as one author's branded method. It is adapted to each act and accurately scoped to that act's own text: on Act One the exaggerated pass tests "Valentine" as a wounded provocation, not a number (it is an Act One moment — the Step-Daughter sings and dances it as the family arrives, before End of Act I); on Act Two the exaggerated pass is how the company discovers why the comedy after Madame Pace must be nervous, not a funny-show, working the casting/procedural scene and Madame Pace's bookkeeping aria — and Act Two is where the keystone "It's taking place now" and the Mother's second silence actually fall; on Act Three it finds the live line between real feeling and the Father's cold philosophy and protects the genuinely Act-Three quiet — the Son's cry found on "horrible," his refusal, the silence after the gunshot, and the fountain narration.

The methods are matched to a semi-amateur room and kept practical: the two-pass read to open each act; Katie Mitchell's objective world-building (facts/questions, back-history, the world of the play, immediate circumstances, events, intentions) as the director-led spine; Stanislavski's units, objectives, super-objective and through-line; actioning (one transitive verb per thought) as the line-level engine, introduced only once events and intentions are agreed — a method that emerged from the Joint Stock workshop process co-led by Max Stafford-Clark and Bill Gaskill in the late 1970s, so the cast holds it as a company rehearsal-room tool, not one director's invention; Uta Hagen's six steps as the actor's private prep checklist; Declan Donnellan's "target" to keep attention outward rather than introspective; and Keith Johnstone's status work for the company/ensemble scenes. Trauma-informed and intimacy practice (the IDC Five Pillars; Ita O'Brien's time-out and choreography; aesthetic distance / depicting-not-reliving) governs how the charged material is named, agreed and deferred; the company adopts the time-out word, check-in/de-role and intake channel as its own practices in Session 1, distinct from the separately signed protocol. Everything is tied to this edition's own decisions — the four-stage Father arc, the Mother's three silences, the Step-

Daughter as moral centre, the Manager's Boy-chair pivot, the Light & Sound score, the two objects, the protocol's contact inventory — and we resist over-intellectualising throughout: do enough table work to share the facts and the questions, then stop.

The five evenings at a glance

THURSDAY 2 JULY
2026

Act One at the table — open the round, then the two-pass read, "Valentine," and the bargain

The round opens here: before any charged material, the company co-writes its Room & Safety Agreement and the director gives a compressed concept / orders-of-reality frame (folding in the orientation the edition's dropped 18/25 June first-read and walk-through would have carried). THEN Act One is worked seated, opened by the two-pass read of its spine scenes (neutral, then exaggerated, then debrief) and run part by part (Rehearsal / Family Arrives / Bargain): facts and questions into decisions, units and objectives, actioning, the Father's four-stage defence ladder, the Step-Daughter as moral centre, "Valentine" as a wounded provocation (an Act One moment), the Mother's first silence and the three fragile lines that fall in Act One — and the words-only groundwork for the Father lifting the Mother's veil.

THURSDAY 9 JULY
2026

Act Two at the table — the two-pass read, the apparition, the shower monologue, the keystone, and the music

Act Two worked seated and OPENED by its two-pass read of the act's spine, adapted so the exaggerated pass is how the company discovers why the comedy after Madame Pace must be NERVOUS, not funny-show — worked on genuinely Act Two material (the casting/procedural scene and Madame Pace's bookkeeping aria); a callback to Act One's "Valentine" may be invoked, but the text read is Act Two's. Then: the Step-Daughter's opening shower monologue, the procedural casting scene and the failure of representation, Madame Pace's apparition (her own performer), reality vs. illusion, the Mother's keystone "It's taking place now" and her second silence (both Act Two), the music (pianist demonstrates tempo only), the tempo gears within the act, and a words-only naming of the act's choreographed-contact moments — including the 'Cry out, mother!' beat.

THURSDAY 16 JULY
2026

Act Three at the table — the two-pass read, the philosophy duel, the refusal, the fountain, the two deaths

Act Three worked seated and OPENED by its two-pass read of the act's spine, adapted so it finds the live line between real feeling and the Father's cold philosophy and protects the genuinely Act-Three quiet — the Son's mirror-speech cry found on 'horrible,' his refusal, the protected silence after the gunshot, and the fountain narration. (The Mother's fragile lines and "It's taking place now" are NOT Act Three lines and are protected in Sessions 1 and 2, where they fall.) Then: the Father's philosophy duel and his four-stage arc, the Son's refusal and mirror speech, the fountain and the two deaths, the Manager's Boy-chair pivot and the ending — the rupture-tempi around the two climaxes — and a careful talked-through (not staged) agreement of the play's choreographed-contact moments, with the gunshot and drowning handled as object work. This evening stays strictly seated, following the block's governing 'table work, not blocking' rule (line 1803) over the looser 'on his feet' phrasing in the 16 July master-

THURSDAY 23 JULY
2026

The whole play integrated — relationships, orders of reality, tempo, comedy, and safety confirmed

The whole play worked integrated and in words only, never staged: relationships read across the full arc; the metatheatre / orders-of-reality applied throughout; tempo-rhythm mapped end to end against the gears built in Sessions 1–3; the nervous comedy and "Valentine" as a wounded provocation; and the charged-scene safety frameworks confirmed — every choreographed-contact moment talked through and confirmed as deferred to the 20 August staging block per the signed protocol. This evening deliberately substitutes the edition's 23 July Light & Sound walk-through (line 1798) with integrated, words-only table work; the full cue list is instead walked end-to-end in Session 5's cued read. No reading-into-action, no touch.

THURSDAY 30 JULY
2026

The cue-called integrated read — and the hand-off to the floor

A full integrated CUED READ of the whole play with the SM calling cues aloud and the pianist marking tempo — Act Two given equal time to Acts One and Three — to feel relationships, scored cues and tempo-rhythm end to end as one continuous experience, confirming what Sessions 1–4 built and standing in for the master schedule's 23 July L&S walk-through by walking the full cue list here; then a clean hand-off to the 20 August staging block. A short voice-rest is inserted between Act One and Act Two so no continuous read crosses the 80-minute line. Close-out business is kept light, and front-loaded, so the read can be a true full read.

		schedule note (line 1796).		
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How we run the room

GROUND RULES

- The room is the work of K. J., "offered as starting points, not as commands" (Portraits, line 1519). At the table we test the readings; we do not perform them. We read to discover, not to correct, and nobody fixes a line reading or locks a character "take" before the relationships have been explored — which is also why each act opens with the two-pass read: the neutral pass deliberately keeps everyone off any settled reading.
- The production's own trauma-informed practices — co-written with the company in Session 1, NOT clauses of the signed protocol. The time-out word: anyone may say "hold" at any moment, for any reason, with no explanation owed and no penalty. We agree and rehearse it on 2 July, before it is ever needed, so it is a normal tool and not an alarm. A daily check-in at 18:00 (one sentence each: "what do I need to take part fully tonight?") and a de-role check-out at 20:55 (name aloud one thing that is your character's and not yours, then leave it on the table). The standing reminder we adopt for ourselves: you are not your character. The exaggerated pass especially is framed as play and bounded by the time-out word — going deliberately too far is an experiment, not a demand to mine real feeling. (These are the IDC/O'Brien-derived practices the company chooses; they are written into the Room & Safety Agreement, not into the signed Intimacy & Consent Protocol.)
- PURE TABLE WORK. Everyone stays seated all five evenings. No blocking, no movement, no physical or intimacy work of any kind at the table — including during the exaggerated pass, which oversizes voice and impulse only, never the body across the table. The play's choreographed-contact moments — the Step-Daughter's "My passion, sir!" hand-on-shoulder; the Father lifting the Mother's veil against her will; Madame Pace's hand under the Step-Daughter's chin; the shop-scene six-inch limit and the screen disappearance; the "Cry out, mother!" head-to-shoulder contact at the end of Act Two; the Mother separating them; the Father/Son held grip in

WHO DOES WHAT

- Director (Kiarash Jamshidi) — leads the analysis, frames each evening, runs the two-pass read at the top of each act-session and its debriefs (asking the company what each pass revealed before giving any reading), keeps the umorismo register (comic and unbearable in the same beat) honest, and settles Player 3's pronoun at or before Session 1 so the stage directions can be adjusted. Reads with joy and momentum; on the neutral pass he protects the flatness, on the exaggerated pass he gives full permission to overshoot.
- Assistant Director — the director's "second pair of eyes" (line 1827): holds a script, takes notes, tracks the agreed events/objectives/actions in the prompt copy, captures what the neutral and exaggerated passes surface (where comedy/danger/feeling lived; what to keep), flags tonal drift, energy drops, and off-message comedy, runs any sub-rehearsal when the director is occupied (e.g. a Player on the Madame Pace dialect while the director works the Mother on "It's taking place now"), and briefs absentees. A valid third party for August intimacy rehearsals when not in the scene. Does not cast, block, or give acting notes directly to actors in a director's session.
- Stage Manager — "the production's spine" (line 1846): booked the five Thursdays at SSA, distributed the Director's Copy and Actor Rehearsal Script and the calendar; during the round of readings keeps attendance, the rehearsal log, and the prompt book (in pencil, key at the front), reads stage directions aloud, times the reads, and calls cues aloud on 30 July (Session 5). Tracks props only from August. A valid third party for August intimacy rehearsals when not in the scene. Does not direct or change the script.
- The Pianist — a credited performer, "fourth Player, in effect" (Light & Sound, line 1752). Attends Session 2 (9 July, Act Two) to demonstrate tempo only — Satie's Gymnopédie No. 1, the Weimar-shop vamp (Weill Bilbao Song at half tempo / a vamp on Mistinguett Mon Homme) — and returns on 30 July

Act Three (protocol, lines 132–148) — are named and discussed in words only and explicitly deferred to the 20 August staging block, routed through the protocol (third party present, doors not closed). The back-room transaction is NOT among them: the production never stages it — "the intensity is in the report, not the display" — so we discuss it only as the reported event the Step-Daughter's account carries, never as deferred choreography.

- The charged scenes are protected by "Bounded bodies, unbounded moral force" (Intimacy & Consent Protocol, line 201) and "the intensity is in the report, not the display" (line 125). We aim for truthful depiction, not re-living: the actor depicts the experience and stays inside the dramatic frame; we never fuel a performance from personal trauma (IDC/aesthetic-distance practice). The exaggerated pass finds the scene's ceiling as a diagnostic; it is sound and scale, not lived distress.
- Consent lives with the actor receiving an action. The Step-Daughter and the Mother (the veil moment) hold absolute veto over their contact (protocol, line 122); a substitute is held ready for each. Consent is revocable at any moment, including in performance (protocol signature, lines 207/231). The script's or director's "permission" is never the same thing as consent.
- From Session 1 (2 July) onward the Step-Daughter and the Mother keep the Child-bundle and the Boy-chair by them throughout, even at the table, "so the company sees the conventions from this session forward" (schedule note, line 1790). The objects are heavier than performers would be; treat every gesture toward them as load-bearing — and note the protocol handles the Boy's gunshot and the Child's drowning "as object, not as person" (line 122): they are careful object-handling, not actor-intimacy work.
- Speaker tags and address are Player 1 / 2 / 3 only, never the momentary role (lines 1736–1739). Player 3's pronoun is settled at or before Session 1 (the part is written for a young man or woman; the director chooses to fit the actor cast, line 1647) so the few stage directions that carry it are adjusted before the act-by-act work uses them.

(Session 5) to mark musical cues by tempo across the integrated read; seated, no staging.

- The company (the nine performers — including Madame Pace's own dedicated performer, who is one of the nine, no longer doubled by a Player, not a tenth track) — read aloud (including both passes of the two-pass read), keep the facts/questions and Hagen sheets, write down the agreed events and actions, and carry the part-notes home. Quiet roles (the Mother, the Son, the Players) are asked the same questions as the leads and take a full part in the exaggerated pass; a round-robin in every session guarantees each speaks; no one sits idle.

- Do not over-intellectualise. We do enough table work to share the facts and the questions, then we get up in August. Every over-talked table minute is a staging minute lost. Read first, talk second; the director asks the actors what they found before offering an interpretation — and the two-pass debriefs are run as questions to the room, not lectures.
- A private intake channel — the production's own provision, not a protocol clause — is open to every performer from tonight: any personal history with sexual coercion, child loss, or suicide can be disclosed confidentially to the director or AD without being named to the company.
- This is a deliberate FIVE-Thursday plan that compresses the edition's SEVEN-Thursday table-work block (18 June – 30 July). The acts are worked in order across Sessions 1–3 (one act per evening, each opened by its two-pass read of that act's spine scenes), the whole play is integrated and the safety frameworks confirmed in Session 4, and a cue-called integrated read with the hand-off to August is Session 5. The dropped 18 June first-read and 25 June walk-through fold into Session 1's opening; Session 4 substitutes the 23 July L&S walk-through with integrated table work and the cue list is walked in Session 5. Where this plan adapts the edition's own master-schedule notes we say so; we do not over-claim fidelity to its calendar.

BRING TO EVERY SESSION

- Director's Copy and Actor Rehearsal Script (Storer translation, lightly modernised and trimmed for pace — "compressed, never gutted", line 1684), distributed by the SM before Session 1.
- A pencil and a two-column Facts / Questions sheet per actor (Mitchell), plus a one-page Hagen six-step sheet (Who am I? / circumstances / relationships / what do I want? / obstacle / what do I do to get it?) to fill for each scene.
- A short transitive-verb list for actioning (from Caldarone & Lloyd-Williams, *Actions: The Actors' Thesaurus*) — verbs that fit "I ____ you" (shock, reassure, intrigue, seduce, tease, threaten, distract).
- A one-line two-pass prompt card at each seat for Sessions 1–3: PASS ONE — flat, words and punctuation and facts only, no acting; PASS TWO — too big, melodrama, full permission; then debrief (what did each pass reveal?). A note that the two passes run on the act's SPINE SCENES, not the whole act, and a reminder that the truthful middle is found in August, on the floor.
- The Child-bundle (white swaddling cloth) and the Boy-chair (wooden chair, black coat, schoolboy's cap, leather satchel) — present from Session 1 on, kept by the Step-Daughter and the Mother.
- The printed, co-written Room & Safety Agreement (drafted Session 1, posted thereafter — the production's own trauma-informed practices) and a copy of the signed Intimacy & Consent Protocol for reference, including its contact inventory (lines 132–148).
- The Light & Sound one-pager (three colours in Act One, the wing radio, and "Valentine" sung live; the shower and the pianist in Act Two; dark stage / lit fountain / hanging bulb / cello drone / Pärt in Act Three). The pianist brings the instrument for Session 2 and returns for Session 5.
- Water, tea, and something to eat for the 19:10/19:25 break and the short second break; name tags for anyone new on Session 1.

SHAPE OF AN EVENING

A single Thursday evening, 18:00–21:00 at SSA Lausanne, everyone seated throughout. 18:00 one-sentence check-in and the evening's frame (5 min). 18:05 a gentle seated vocal/breath warm-up to arrive in the voice (10 min) — the sessions are vocally heavy, and the exaggerated pass especially pushes the voice, so we warm up cold voices first and rest the voice deliberately at the breaks; this happens EVERY evening, Session 1 included. 18:15 first focused block — on Sessions 1–3 this OPENS with the two-pass read of the act's SPINE SCENES (neutral pass, debrief, exaggerated pass, debrief), which fits ~55 min because it is a selected span, not the whole act; the whole-act exposure is reserved for Session 5's cued read. 19:10 a 15-minute break (the trauma-informed/Equity baseline we adopt: a real break inside every 80 minutes). 19:25 second block, itself broken by a scheduled 5-minute second break around 20:05–20:10 to honour the 80-minute rule across the charged back half (anyone may also call "hold" for a 2-minute pause at any time). A short round-robin so every actor — including the quiet roles — speaks aloud before the close, in EVERY session. Homework set around 20:50; de-role check-out and close at 20:55. The architecture matters more than the clock; we may run a beat long or short inside the window, but we stop talking the moment talk stops earning its keep. Session 1 carries extra foundational material (room & safety agreement, concept/orders-of-reality frame, the folded-in first-read/walk-through orientation) before the act work, so its front-loaded talk is trimmed and the two-pass read protected rather than raced; Sessions 4 and 5 protect the integrated read the same way by moving close-out business off the read. Session 5 inserts a short voice-rest between Act One and Act Two so no stretch of continuous reading crosses the 80-minute line.

REMEMBER Table work serves the floor — we read to discover, not to perform, and we get up the moment talk

stops earning its keep.

The methods we use

The two-pass read: neutral first, exaggerated second, on the act's spine scenes (then find the truth in August)

Open each act's work with two opposite reads of a SELECTED span of the act — its spine scenes, not the whole act (so the two passes plus two debriefs fit ~55 min; the whole-act exposure is held for Session 5's single cued read). PASS ONE is neutral / flat / mechanical — just the words, the punctuation, the sense and the facts; no acting, no emotional colour, no line-readings (a monotone or deadpan read; a fast "Italian run" is the speed variant). PASS TWO is deliberately exaggerated / over-the-top — push every impulse to the extreme, play it too big, melodrama, full permission, oversize emotion and voice (seated; never the body across the table). A structured debrief follows each pass. The truthful middle is NOT decided at the table; it is found later, on the floor, in August. This is the explicit FIRST exercise of Sessions 1, 2 and 3, adapted to each act and accurately scoped to that act's own text.

WHY The neutral pass lets the room HEAR the structure, the argument and the facts undisguised by performance, and — the load-bearing rationale, well attested — it stops actors locking premature or "indicated" line-readings (a line reading produces copied delivery, not discovered behaviour); it also lowers day-one performance pressure. The exaggerated pass finds the emotional CEILING so the truthful middle becomes findable (you can't find "enough" until you've overshot it), breaks inhibition and self-consciousness, and surfaces where the comedy, danger and real feeling actually live. Scoping it to the spine scenes is not a compromise but arithmetic: Session 5 allots ~40 min to ONE straight cued read of a single act, and a flat pass plus an over-the-top pass plus two debriefs of a whole act would run 80+ minutes and either overflow or silently truncate the act — so we read the spine deliberately and keep the whole-act hearing for the cued read. The caution: sustained exaggeration is result-acting / indicating, so it is named as a diagnostic experiment, not the performance. There is no single branded source: this is a verified composite of Mitchell's neutral fact-first table-work, the anti-line-reading principle (Donnellan; Stareable; No Film School), exaggeration-to-find-range (StageMilk; Casting Networks), and Stanislavski/Knebel's Active Analysis — "the best analysis of a play is to take action in the given circumstances" — which the neutral pass (establishing given circumstances) and exaggerated pass (action-as-investigation) together set up. We attribute it as a composite, honestly, not to one author.

Read to discover, not to perform (and then get up)

Read scenes through before opening discussion; the director asks the actors what they found before offering a reading. Do enough table work to share the facts and questions, then carry the analysis onto the August floor rather than exhausting it seated.

WHY Late in his career, after decades of work at the MAT, Stanislavski came to distrust long table analysis because it opened a gap between the actor's mental and physical work — "the best analysis of a play is to take action in the given circumstances." Alfreds and Donnellan restate the caution against over-fixing. For a limited-evening company every over-talked table night is a staging night lost, so tightness is a value, not a shortcut.

Hold the umorismo — comic and unbearable in the same beat

Refuse both failure modes: farce (the wounds become gags) and cold philosophy (the anguish goes flat). Keep the laugh and the wound simultaneous: "earn the laugh, then let it curdle in the same breath" (the Step-Daughter's Act One "Valentine"); "the comedy must cost something — every laugh uncomfortable, never a punchline" (Act One playing-note, line 1990). The exaggerated pass is the diagnostic that exposes whether a beat is merely funny-show or genuinely nervous.

WHY Pirandello's 1908 *L'Umoreismo* splits the register in two: the merely comic is the *avvertimento del contrario* — the bare perception of the opposite, where you just laugh; *umorismo* proper is the *sentimento del contrario* — the reflective feeling that reverses the laugh into the painful thing underneath. The "curdle" the edition asks for IS the move from *avvertimento* to *sentimento*: Madame Pace's audience "must laugh at her first line... must regret laughing by her last" (line 2991). Naming the two terms makes the register teachable — the cast knows exactly which half they are missing when a beat plays as a mere joke. Get it wrong and the whole production fails its subject.

Know which layer of the play you are in, minute to minute

Name aloud the nested fictions and place every performer in one, in the edition's own terms: the contingent, vain Actors-playing-Actors; the Manager, who "plays a director first" and becomes the audience's stand-in only because he reacts as they do (line 1601); the six fixed Characters who are condemned to BE their one scene; and Madame Pace, conjured by the arrangement of the stage as "the seventh Character — and now her own performer" (line 1665), carried by one of the nine performers. For the Mother, do not import "doesn't know she has a role" theory; use the edition's behavioural language — see principle 6. Apply this orders-of-reality frame throughout, not only on day one (it is revisited explicitly across Session 4's integrated work).

WHY Pirandello invented the modern theatre-within-the-theatre with this play and the architecture is the meaning; the central conflict is ontological — who is more real. The edition's only explicit count is the seven Characters (the Six plus Madame Pace as the seventh, line 1665), and it asks the Manager to be played as a tired director first, not as "I am the audience" (line 1601). Actors who do not know their layer cannot play the collisions the play runs on.

Keep the focus outward — target and action, not introspection

For each beat name the specific external thing the character needs and what they are doing to whom: one transitive verb per thought (actioning: "I [verb] you" — shock, reassure, seduce, threaten), and a specific target at a measurable distance (Donnellan). Redirect any "I feel..." note into "what am I doing this to, and what does it have that I need?" This is also how the exaggerated pass is brought back toward truth: replace "feel angry" with an active verb aimed at the partner, so emotion arrives as a by-product of doing.

WHY Donnellan: "you can never know what you are doing until you first know what you are doing it to." Actioning — developed in the Joint Stock workshop process co-led by Stafford-Clark and Gaskill, so it is a rehearsal-room company method — gives "a clarity of purpose for every line" and a choice that is recoverable and repeatable over a run, exactly what a semi-amateur cast needs to stay consistent. It also keeps the Father from lecturing ("panic hidden under intelligence, never a lecture", line 1990) and the Step-Daughter forensic ("evidence laid down, not anger screamed").

Score the objects and the silences, not the tears

Build the Mother's role "around the object, not around tears" — the Child-bundle as her anchor (checked when men argue, covered when attacked, held lower when the Son turns away, first felt gone before the fountain) and the three distinct silences played differently. Protect her four fragile lines, placing each where it actually falls: three in Act One ("Stop him"; "Not in front of her"; "But you drove me away") and one in Act Two ("My son —"), each given "a half-second of its own air." Her keystone "It's taking place now" is an ACT TWO line and is protected there — in Session 1's and Session 2's two-pass debriefs the room does not let louder energy roll over the fragile lines that fall in those acts, even at full size. Her one charged contact — the Father lifting her veil against her will in Act One — is hers to control: her actor holds the speed of the lift and an absolute veto (protocol, lines 134, 122), and it is worked in words at the table and choreographed in August.

WHY The Mother is "the fixed wound of the family, and the production's silent centre" (line 1538); the edition's division is that "the Father explains the wound, the Step-Daughter exposes it, the Son refuses it — and the Mother carries it." She "does not become cleverer... she becomes more unavoidable." Her keystone "It's taking place now" is "the key to the whole production" (line 3093) and it lands in Act Two (the line itself at line 3326, before Act III opens at 3353), which is why its protection belongs to the Act Two work, not Act Three's. The veil-lift is the one moment a body acts on her against her will, so her control of it is load-bearing and must be named at the table before any body can carry it.

Bounded bodies, unbounded moral force — depict, never re-live

Name the play's choreographed-contact moments plainly and establish each one's function (IDC Context pillar): the Step-Daughter's "My passion, sir!" hand-on-shoulder; the Father lifting the Mother's veil; Madame Pace's hand under the chin; the shop-scene six-inch limit and the screen disappearance; the "Cry out, mother!" head-to-shoulder contact at the end of Act Two; the Mother separating them; the Father/Son held grip in Act Three (protocol, lines 132–148). Agree they will be set as binding choreography in August, never improvised, with a third party present; the goal is truthful depiction inside the frame, not re-experiencing (aesthetic distance). The back-room transaction is NOT staged and is not on this list — it is the reported event the Step-Daughter's account carries (line 114). The Boy's gunshot and the Child's drowning are object-handling "as object, not as person" (line 122), heavy and careful, not actor-intimacy work. At the table we discuss and lay groundwork only — and the exaggerated pass never touches; it scales voice and impulse, not contact.

WHY The protocol's governing line is "Bounded bodies, unbounded moral force" (line 201) and "the intensity is in the report, not the display" (line 125). The protocol is explicit that the back room is never shown (line 114) and that the most physically demanding actor-contact beat after the shop scene is the "Cry out, mother!" moment (line 144) — so the table talk must track the protocol's actual inventory, not an invented triad. Literature on trauma-informed training is explicit that fuelling performance with personal trauma scars performers; choreography converts a dangerous improvisation into a repeatable, safe sequence. The play is itself about the ethics of depiction.

The Sessions

SESSION 1 Thursday 2 July 2026

Act One at the table — open the round, then the two-pass read, "Valentine," and the bargain

The round opens here: before any charged material, the company co-writes its Room & Safety Agreement and the director gives a compressed concept / orders-of-reality frame (folding in the orientation the edition's dropped 18/25 June first-read and walk-through would have carried). THEN Act One is worked seated, opened by the two-pass read

of its spine scenes (neutral, then exaggerated, then debrief) and run part by part (Rehearsal / Family Arrives / Bargain): facts and questions into decisions, units and objectives, actioning, the Father's four-stage defence ladder, the Step-Daughter as moral centre, "Valentine" as a wounded provocation (an Act One moment), the Mother's first silence and the three fragile lines that fall in Act One — and the words-only groundwork for the Father lifting the Mother's veil.

GOALS FOR THE EVENING

- Open the whole round safely: co-write and post the Room & Safety Agreement (the company's OWN trauma-informed practices) and give a compressed concept / orders-of-reality frame BEFORE any charged material is read, folding in the whole-play orientation and concept walk-through the edition's dropped 18/25 June sessions would have carried.
- Run the two-pass read of the Act One spine scenes as the first exercise: a neutral / flat pass (words, punctuation, facts only), then a deliberately exaggerated / over-the-top pass that leans HARD into the Act One comedy and into "Valentine," then a structured debrief of what each revealed — so the company hears Act One's structure, finds its ceiling, and tests whether "Valentine" reads as a wound or a number, before any choice is locked.
- Turn the Act One questions into agreed decisions and a shared immediate-circumstances picture (the 24 hours before each part); divide Act One into units and name a playable objective for each, beginning actioning of the key exchanges.
- Score the Father's Act One defence as an escalation, not a repetition: I meant well → you misunderstand me → do not judge me by one moment → I am trapped by what she says I am; establish the Step-Daughter's forensic through-line and "Valentine" as a provocation from a wound (the back room discussed only as the reported event her account carries, never as deferred choreography).
- Place and protect the Mother's first silence and her three Act One fragile lines ("Stop him"; "Not in front of her"; "But you drove me away"); do words-only groundwork on the Father lifting her veil (its function, her speed-control and veto, flagged for August); confirm the Child-bundle / Boy-chair convention now sits with her and the Step-Daughter, and mark the Part I / Father-drive tempo gear.

THE EVENING, HOUR BY HOUR

18:00

Welcome, check-in, and the frame

Name tags for anyone new; the director signals "one team, one goal" and keeps it short. One-sentence check-in from each person. The director frames the whole arc: three acts in order (each opened by a two-pass read of its spine), then integrate, then the cued read — and names that this five-evening plan compresses the edition's seven-Thursday block, with tonight folding in the first-read/walk-through orientation.

18:05

Seated vocal/breath warm-up

10-minute gentle seated warm-up before any reading — and especially before the exaggerated pass, which pushes volume. Warm up cold voices first, not after twenty minutes of policy talk.

18:15

Co-write the Room & Safety Agreement (the production's own practices)

Brief and collaborative, BEFORE any charged material: agree and rehearse the time-out word "hold"; agree the check-in and de-role check-out; name the private intake channel; settle Player 3's pronoun. Read aloud the protocol's governing line "Bounded bodies, unbounded moral force" and that the protocol's seven Thursdays (of which we work five) are table work only (line 179). State plainly that these practices are the company's own (IDC/O'Brien-derived), written into the Room & Safety Agreement, NOT clauses of the signed protocol. SM posts the agreement. Keep to ~12 minutes.

18:27

Concept and orders of reality (compressed; folds in the 18/25 June orientation)

Director lays out modern dress, minimal sculptural staging, the three stripped settings, the nine-performer sizing (including Madame Pace's own performer as one of the nine), and the layers in the edition's terms: Actors-playing-Actors, the Manager who plays a director first (line 1601), the six fixed Characters, Madame Pace the conjured seventh (line 1665). ~13 minutes, concrete not lecturing — this carries the whole-play orientation and concept walk-through the dropped first-read/walk-through evenings would have given. Introduce the Child-bundle and Boy-chair as conventions; the Step-Daughter and Mother take them up now and keep them by them.

18:40

Two-pass read of the Act One spine scenes

The act's first exercise, on a selected span (the family's arrival, "Valentine," and the bargain spine), not the whole act. PASS ONE neutral: read the spine flat — words, punctuation, sense and facts only, no acting, no line-readings (drop to a fast "Italian run" if anyone keeps colouring it). Short debrief: what are the facts, the events, what each character wants, where the thought turns, what we assumed that the flat read did not support. PASS TWO exaggerated: read it again deliberately too big — melodrama, full permission, oversize voice and impulse, leaning HARD into the Act One comedy and into "Valentine"; seated, no contact. Short debrief: what did the big version reveal that the flat one hid; where did it get funny, dangerous or raw; did "Valentine" read as a wound or a number when over-played; what to keep. Name aloud that the truthful middle is found in August. (~55 min including both debriefs.)

19:25

Break (15 min)

Water, tea, food. Rest the voice — the exaggerated pass is loud.

19:40

Units & objectives + the Father's escalation ladder, actioned

Resolve the parked Part I questions into decisions; agree the immediate circumstances (the wasted morning) and that Part I plays "dry and worn... add nothing beyond what is written" (line 1891). Divide the arrival of the Six into units; name one playable objective per unit. Work the Father's long speeches as "panic hidden under intelligence, never a lecture" (line 1990); lay the four rungs in order (control/justify → disarm → plead → trap) and action a sample with one transitive verb per thought. Mark the tempo gear-change as the Father/Step-Daughter drive enters.

20:05

Second break (5 min)

Short scheduled breather across the charged back half. Rest the voice.

20:10

The Step-Daughter forensic, "Valentine," and the Mother (words only)

Action the Step-Daughter's attack as "evidence laid down, not anger screamed; cold revenge, not melodrama"; "Valentine" worked as a provocation from a wound — "earn the laugh, then let it curdle" — the cheeky café-concert number weaponising her impudence (line 1747), never a mere turn. From Madame Pace onward the comedy "must cost something — every laugh uncomfortable." The back-room transaction is discussed only AS THE REPORTED EVENT her account carries (line 114) — never deferred choreography. Then the Mother: place her first silence; read each Act One fragile line — "Stop him"; "Not in front of her"; "But you drove me away" — giving each "a half-second of its own air"; score her hands on the Child-bundle. The veil-lift in words only: name its function (a man acts on her against her will), confirm she controls the lift speed and holds absolute veto (protocol lines 134, 122), flag for August. No physical work.

20:40

Round-robin: what does your character want in Act One?

Every actor, including the Players, names their Act One objective and target out loud. The Players settle their Lausanne register — local, modern, amateur-in-the-best-sense.

Homework and de-role close

Set homework; de-role check-out; confirm next Thursday is Act Two, opened by its own two-pass read of the Act Two spine.

EXERCISES AT THE TABLE

The two-pass read of the Act One spine (neutral, then exaggerated)

On a selected span — the family's arrival, "Valentine," and the bargain spine — not the whole act. PASS ONE: read seated, flat and mechanical — words, punctuation, sense and facts only, no acting or line-readings; if inflection creeps in, switch to a fast "Italian run" to defeat it. Debrief 1: extract facts, events and intentions; flag assumptions the flat read did not support. PASS TWO: read it again deliberately over-the-top — too big, melodrama, full permission, voice and impulse oversized, leaning hard into the comedy and into "Valentine"; seated, no contact. Debrief 2: what the big version revealed that the flat one hid; where it turned funny, dangerous or raw; whether "Valentine" read as a wound or a number; what to keep. State that the truthful middle is found in August, on the floor.

YIELDS The neutral pass surfaces Act One's structure, facts and given circumstances and stops the company locking premature line-readings (Mitchell's neutral fact-first table-work; the anti-line-reading principle). The exaggerated pass finds the act's emotional ceiling, breaks day-one inhibition and shows where the comedy and the wounds actually live — and is the precise diagnostic for whether "Valentine," an Act One moment, is a wounded provocation or a mere number — so the calibrated middle becomes findable later. Working the spine (not the whole act) keeps it inside ~55 min, reconciled with Session 5's single-act read time. Underpinned by Active Analysis (Stanislavski/Knebel): the passes set up action-in-the-given-circumstances on the floor.

Units & objectives + actioning the Father and the Step-Daughter

Read each part; mark a slash at every turning point to divide it into units; write one active-verb objective per unit toward each super-objective (Mitchell's sequence: agree events/intentions, then read using them as a guide). The Father and Step-Daughter then split their lines into thoughts and assign one transitive verb per thought fitting "I ____ you" (Caldarone & Lloyd-Williams), spoken in the manner of the verb at the specific person — seated, no movement.

YIELDS Stanislavski/Mitchell give the act a beat-by-beat structure of change and a through-line; Joint Stock / Stafford-Clark & Gaskill actioning gives "a clarity of purpose for every line" and a repeatable choice — keeping the Father from lecturing and the Step-Daughter forensic rather than melodramatic, exactly what a semi-amateur cast needs.

The fragile-line air check, with the veil named

The Mother reads each of her three Act One lines ("Stop him"; "Not in front of her"; "But you drove me away") while the louder actors deliberately do NOT roll over her; the room gives each line a half-second of silence on either side and notes the cost in her hands on the bundle. Then the veil-lift is described in words only — function, her speed control, her veto — and flagged for August.

YIELDS Protects the production's silent centre at the table, in timing, and gives her one charged contact its words-only groundwork before any staging can bury her (line 1547; protocol line 134). The keystone "It's taking place now" and "My son —" are Act Two lines and are protected in Session 2, where they fall.

QUESTIONS TO PUT TO THE ROOM

- *After the neutral pass: what is actually happening in Act One — the facts and the events — and what did you assume the act was that the flat read did not support?*
- *After the exaggerated pass: where did Act One suddenly get funny, dangerous or raw when you played it too big — and did "Valentine" read as a wound or a number? Which discoveries do you want to keep (at real scale, in August)?*

- *Where exactly does the Father's defence move up a rung — and where is he merely repeating himself (which the edition forbids)?*
- *The Step-Daughter is 'the moral centre, not the Father with his philosophy.' Where in Act One does the room first feel that, and where should a laugh in the bargain 'cost something' — turn from avvertimento to sentimento?*
- *The veil-lift is the one moment a body acts on the Mother. What is its dramatic function, and what does her holding the speed and the veto protect?*

HOMEWORK

Finalise your units-and-objectives for Act One and your Hagen sheet for your Act One scene, grounded in tonight's agreed facts and in what your two passes revealed. Father: write your four rungs in your own words and one transitive verb per major speech. Step-Daughter: action the Madame Pace evidence as cold testimony, and decide how "Valentine" lands as a provocation from a wound — where the laugh curdles. Mother: rehearse your three Act One fragile lines aloud with a half-second of air around each, decide what your hands do on the Child-bundle at three named moments, and sit with the veil-lift's function (its choreography waits for August). Players: bring your Lausanne register choice. Begin learning Act One lines now toward the 20 August off-book milestone — words don't seep in by osmosis.

BY THE END

By the end the round is safely open — a co-written, posted Room & Safety Agreement (time-out word, check-in/de-role, intake channel), Player 3's pronoun settled, and a compressed orders-of-reality frame shared that also carries the dropped first-read/walk-through orientation. Act One has been opened by the two-pass read of its spine (neutral then exaggerated, both debriefed, with "Valentine" tested as a wounded provocation), divided into units with an agreed objective each, the Part I / Father-drive tempo gear marked, the Father's four-rung escalation laid in order, a sample of his and the Step-Daughter's key lines actioned, her forensic through-line agreed (the back room understood as reported, not staged), the Mother's first silence placed and her three Act One fragile lines protected in timing, the veil-lift's function and her control of it established in words, and the two stage objects now at the table from tonight on.

Act Two at the table — the two-pass read, the apparition, the shower monologue, the keystone, and the music

Act Two worked seated and OPENED by its two-pass read of the act's spine, adapted so the exaggerated pass is how the company discovers why the comedy after Madame Pace must be NERVOUS, not funny-show — worked on genuinely Act Two material (the casting/procedural scene and Madame Pace's bookkeeping aria); a callback to Act One's "Valentine" may be invoked, but the text read is Act Two's. Then: the Step-Daughter's opening shower monologue, the procedural casting scene and the failure of representation, Madame Pace's apparition (her own performer), reality vs. illusion, the Mother's keystone "It's taking place now" and her second silence (both Act Two), the music (pianist demonstrates tempo only), the tempo gears within the act, and a words-only naming of the act's choreographed-contact moments — including the 'Cry out, mother!' beat.

GOALS FOR THE EVENING

- Run the two-pass read of the Act Two spine as the first exercise, adapted to this act: the neutral pass surfaces the act's true shape (the monologue OPENS it before the procedural casting scene) and its facts; the exaggerated pass deliberately overplays the casting scene and Madame Pace's aria so the room FEELS why the comedy must be nervous, not funny-show — kept to genuinely Act Two material, with "Valentine" referenced only as an Act One callback, not read here.
- Honour the act's true shape: the Step-Daughter's monologue OPENS Act Two (she erupts onto the upper platform with both objects before the procedural casting scene, lines 2591, 2621); read it in its real position so the company feels the brisk-procedural-vs-exposed-solo contrast.
- Work the procedural stretches "brisk and businesslike" so the shower-light, the apparition and the Mother's cry land hard against them (line 2595); understand the casting scene as the failure of representation (the Leading Man and Lady falsify it on purpose) and use Johnstone status work to map the company's power dynamics; mark the tempo gears within the act.
- Build Madame Pace as apparition and bookkeeper — full comic accent on arrival, full obscenity by exit, "the bookkeeping is the body of her," the laugh curdling on "he pay cash" (avvertimento to sentimento in one line).
- Place the Mother's second silence and her keystone line "It's taking place now" (the key to the production, line 3093; the line at 3326, in Act Two), and protect them at full size; name in words only the act's choreographed-contact moments — Madame Pace's hand under the chin, the shop-scene six-inch limit and screen disappearance, and especially the 'Cry out, mother!' head-to-shoulder contact (protocol line 144, the most demanding actor-contact beat after the shop scene) — all deferred to August.

THE EVENING, HOUR BY HOUR

18:00

Check-in, warm-up, objects, pianist welcomed

One-sentence check-in; seated vocal/breath warm-up. Step-Daughter and Mother take up the Child-bundle and Boy-chair. The pianist is welcomed as the credited fourth Player and will demonstrate tempo only tonight, seated.

18:15

Two-pass read of the Act Two spine

The act's first exercise, on a selected span (the opening monologue, the procedural casting scene, the apparition and Madame Pace's aria, the cry), not the whole act. PASS ONE neutral: read the spine flat — words, punctuation, facts only — so the room hears its true shape (monologue first, then procedural casting, the apparition, the cry) without colour. Debrief 1: the facts, the events, the act's actual order. PASS TWO

exaggerated: read it deliberately too big, and lean HARD into the comedy of the casting scene and Madame Pace's aria — full permission. Debrief 2: with the comedy overplayed, the room feels exactly why it cannot stay funny-show — where the laugh has to curdle, why the comedy must be NERVOUS. ("Valentine" is referenced only as an Act One callback; it is not read here — its work was done in Session 1.) Name that the truthful middle is found in August. (~55 min with debriefs.)

19:00

The opening monologue, in its true position

Read the Step-Daughter's single sustained monologue where it actually sits (lines 2591, 2621): she erupts onto the upper platform with both objects — tender to the Child-bundle, then the wound turned the other way at the Boy-chair. Seated; the revolver-from-the-pocket is discussed as a future staged moment, deferred to August. Find the depicting-not-reliving line out loud. (~10 min.)

19:10

Break (15 min)

Rest the voice; water and food.

19:25

The casting scene + status work on the company

Read the casting/procedural stretch businesslike and quick, landing hard against the exposed solo just heard. Establish that the Leading Man and Leading Lady are BAD at re-enacting the Characters on purpose — "the horror is that it is good, and still false" (line 3093); Player 2's "I have been made a fool of by considerably better" is "not a punchline. It is the truth" (line 3133). Then a Johnstone play-the-status read: run a slice with the company actors a point higher, then lower, then alternating raise/lower line by line — seated, voice and eye-contact only. Mark the act's tempo gears: procedural brisk vs. exposed solo vs. airless apparition.

19:55

Madame Pace — apparition and bookkeeping

Read the aria. "Play the comedy of her accent at full strength on her arrival; play the obscenity beneath it at full strength by her exit" (line 1667). "Do not let her become an accent joke. The bookkeeping is the body of her." Mark the curdle precisely on "he clean, he polite, he pay cash" — bare comic perception (avvertimento) turning to reflective disgust (sentimento). The Step-Daughter "does not flirt with Madame Pace; she is being handled by her"; Madame Pace's hand-under-the-chin named as an August choreographed-contact moment. Words only.

20:05

Second break (5 min)

Short scheduled breather across the charged back half. Rest the voice.

20:10

The pianist's tempo + the Mother's keystone + naming the contact moments

Pianist plays, seated, tempo only: Satie's Gymnopédie No. 1 (the speed under the monologue, once through); the Weimar-shop vamp (Weill Bilbao Song at half tempo / a vamp on Mistinguett Mon Homme) and exactly where it dies mid-bar on "You old devil. You murderess." Then place the Mother's second silence (being made to watch her daughter's worst hour) and read her Act Two fragile line "My son —" with its half-second of air; read "It's taking place now. It happens all the time" — "like a stone learning to speak" (line 3326) — naming it the key to the whole production (line 3093) and protecting it from being rolled over even at full size. Then, words only, name the act's choreographed-contact moments for August: Madame Pace's hand under the chin; the shop-scene six-inch limit and two-second screen disappearance; and the 'Cry out, mother!' contact (Step-Daughter's cheek to the Father's shoulder, one hand on his upper arm, he does not reciprocate, the Mother breaks them — protocol line 144), flagged as the most demanding actor-contact beat after the shop scene. No staging.

20:45

Round-robin and close

Fast round-robin so every actor — the Mother, the Son, each Player — names one thing they found in Act Two; set homework; de-role check-out; confirm next Thursday is Act Three, opened by its own two-pass read of the Act Three spine.

EXERCISES AT THE TABLE

The two-pass read of the Act Two spine (the comedy diagnostic)

On a selected span (the opening monologue, the procedural casting scene, the apparition and aria, the cry), not the whole act. PASS ONE neutral: read the spine flat, words and facts only, to hear its true shape (monologue first, then procedural casting, apparition, cry). Debrief 1: facts, events, real order. PASS TWO exaggerated: read it deliberately too big and overplay the comedy of the casting scene and Madame Pace's aria to the hilt — full permission, seated, no contact. Debrief 2: with the comedy pushed past its limit, the room locates where the laugh must curdle and agrees the comedy must be nervous not funny-show. State the truthful middle is found in August.

YIELDS The neutral pass establishes Act Two's facts and its true order; the exaggerated pass is the precise diagnostic for THIS act — overshooting the comedy is how the company discovers, in their bodies and ears, why it must stay nervous (the avvertimento that must curdle to sentimento). Worked strictly on Act Two text (the casting scene and the aria); "Valentine" was tested in Session 1, where it falls, and is only a callback here. Working the spine keeps it inside ~55 min, reconciled with Session 5's single-act read time. Anti-line-reading + exaggeration-to-find-range, on Pirandello's most dangerous comic material.

Play-the-status casting read

Run the casting scene seated, first with each company actor one status point higher than instinct, then one lower, then alternating raise-self / lower-partner line by line (Johnstone), using only voice, eye-contact and the 'er' marker — no movement.

YIELDS Johnstone: makes the company's ensemble power dynamics legible and tunable, which is exactly what the vain/working/curious trio and the Manager need; clarifies who blocks and who accepts.

The curdle-point mark-up

Read Madame Pace's aria and, as a room, agree and pencil the precise word where the avvertimento (the laugh) must turn to the sentimento (disgust) — 'he pay cash' — and where the vamp dies mid-bar ('You old devil. You murderess.'). Pianist demonstrates the tempo of both.

YIELDS Locks the umorismo mechanics of the play's most sensitive sequence in sound and timing before staging — "the audience must laugh at her first line... regret laughing by her last."

QUESTIONS TO PUT TO THE ROOM

- *After the exaggerated pass: with the comedy pushed too far, where did it stop being funny and start being frightening — and what does that tell you about how nervous, not funny-show, it has to be?*
- *When the Leading Man and Lady re-enact the scene 'well, and still false' — what exactly is false, and what does that tell us about depicting vs. living?*
- *Where is Madame Pace funny (avvertimento), and where do we as a room first regret laughing (sentimento)?*
- *'It's taking place now' is the key to the whole production, and it lands here in Act Two. What keeps it — and the Mother's second silence — from being rolled over by the louder energy around it?*
- *The 'Cry out, mother!' contact is the most demanding actor-contact moment after the shop scene. What does the agreed blocking protect, and what carries the closeness the bodies do not enact?*

HOMEWORK Step-Daughter: live with the opening monologue; bring a Hagen sheet for it and decide the exact turn from tenderness to the wound. Madame Pace's performer: drill the dialect with no protective irony and bookkeep the aria — know the ledger cold. Mother: rehearse the keystone line "It's taking place now" and your second silence and "My son —"; decide what your hands do on the Child-bundle through the aria (the grip becoming a fist on 'he pay cash'). Company actors: bring one status choice per scene. Everyone: keep learning lines toward the 20 August Act One off-book milestone.

BY THE END

By the end Act Two has been opened by the two-pass read of its spine (the exaggerated pass having shown the company why the comedy must be nervous, worked strictly on Act Two text), read in its true shape (monologue opening it), its procedural spine agreed as brisk-and-businesslike, its tempo gears marked, the company's status dynamics mapped, Madame Pace built as apparition-and-bookkeeper with the curdle point marked, the Satie and Weimar-vamp tempi demonstrated and their cut-points fixed in the ear, the Mother's second silence, her line "My son —," and her keystone "It's taking place now" placed and protected, and the act's choreographed-contact moments named in words — Madame Pace's chin, the shop-scene limit and screen, and the 'Cry out, mother!' beat — all deferred to August.

Act Three at the table — the two-pass read, the philosophy duel, the refusal, the fountain, the two deaths

Act Three worked seated and OPENED by its two-pass read of the act's spine, adapted so it finds the live line between real feeling and the Father's cold philosophy and protects the genuinely Act-Three quiet — the Son's mirror-speech cry found on 'horrible,' his refusal, the protected silence after the gunshot, and the fountain narration. (The Mother's fragile lines and "It's taking place now" are NOT Act Three lines and are protected in Sessions 1 and 2, where they fall.) Then: the Father's philosophy duel and his four-stage arc, the Son's refusal and mirror speech, the fountain and the two deaths, the Manager's Boy-chair pivot and the ending — the rupture-tempi around the two climaxes — and a careful talked-through (not staged) agreement of the play's choreographed-contact moments, with the gunshot and drowning handled as object work. This evening stays strictly seated, following the block's governing 'table work, not blocking' rule (line 1803) over the looser 'on his feet' phrasing in the 16 July master-schedule note (line 1796).

GOALS FOR THE EVENING

- Run the two-pass read of the Act Three spine as the first exercise, adapted to this act: the exaggerated pass deliberately overshoots both real feeling and cold philosophy so the room finds the LIVE line between them — where the Father's argument must stay autobiographical panic, not paragraphs — while the neutral pass and the room protect the act's OWN quiet: the Son's cry on 'horrible,' the silence after the gunshot, the fountain narration (not the Mother's fragile lines or "It's taking place now," which belong to Sessions 1 and 2).
- Score the Father's four-stage arc end to end: control → injury → attack → horror, escalating in desperation, "the point made in his panic, not his paragraphs" (line 3566).
- Place and time the Step-Daughter's three cuts and find where they push the Father into the wall of his own argument; mark the rupture-tempi around the two climaxes so Session 5 confirms tempo rather than discovering it.
- Work the Son's refusal ("every line is a door closing"), his single moment of looking up ("Exactly what it was, sir; exactly that," line 3607), the mirror speech (the cry found on 'horrible,' not before, lines 3608–3609) and the fountain narration; establish the climax register — "carry it by stillness, not volume"; "the silence after the shot is the loudest thing in the play."
- Talk through in words only the protocol's choreographed-contact moments in Act Three (the Father/Son held grip, line 148) and recap those from earlier acts; agree the gunshot and drowning are object-handling "as object, not as person" (line 122), not intimacy work; name the Manager's Boy-chair pivot — all physical choreography deferred to 20 August via the protocol; the evening stays seated.

THE EVENING, HOUR BY HOUR

18:00

Check-in, warm-up, objects in place

Check-in; seated warm-up; in Act Three the Mother holds both children — the Child-bundle in her lap and the Boy-chair at her knee — so both objects are by her tonight. Note aloud that tonight is strictly seated table work (line 1803), not the 'on his feet' phrasing of the 16 July master note.

18:15

Two-pass read of the Act Three spine

The act's first exercise, on a selected span (the philosophy duel, the Son's refusal and mirror speech, the fountain and the two deaths), not the whole act, adapted. PASS ONE neutral: read the spine flat — words, punctuation, facts only — surfacing the argument's logic, where the thought turns, the two deaths as plain

events; the room deliberately gives the act's OWN quiet its air even when flat — the Son's mirror-speech cry, the silence after the gunshot, the fountain narration. Debrief 1: the facts and the structure of the duel. PASS TWO exaggerated: read it deliberately too big, overshooting both raw feeling AND cold philosophy. Debrief 2: with both extremes overshot, the room locates the LIVE line between them — where the Father's philosophy must be panic not paragraphs, where real feeling lives against the cold argument — and re-confirms what must stay protected and quiet (the cry on 'horrible,' the silence after the shot, the fountain). Name that the truthful middle is found in August. (~55 min with debriefs.)

19:00

The philosophy duel begins

Begin Act Three Part I. Score the Father's arc: control → injury → attack → horror. Apply the playing-note: his defence "must escalate in desperation, never merely repeat... the point is made in his panic, not his paragraphs" (line 3566). Action his lines so the philosophy stays autobiographical, not abstract — using what the exaggerated pass just exposed about the live line. (~10 min into the block; continues conceptually after the break.)

19:10

Break (15 min)

Rest the voice; water and food.

19:25

The three cuts, the rupture-tempi, and the Son's refusal

Place and time the Step-Daughter's three cuts, including 'His reality. He always knew exactly where to find me.' Find how "the same Step-Daughter who exposed him in Act One pushes him into the wall in Act Three"; note the cello drone dies as she cuts him (Light & Sound). Mark the rupture-tempi where the argument's pulse breaks open around each climax. Then the Son: "unmoveable, not still," every line a door closing; his single look-up — 'Exactly what it was, sir; exactly that' (line 3607); the mirror speech so the cry is found mid-thought on 'horrible,' not pre-loaded (lines 3608–3609); the fountain narration as his only continuous sentence.

19:55

The fountain, the two deaths, the Manager's pivot

Read the climax for register: "carry it by stillness, not volume." The Son's account flat; the Child's drowning told, hidden by the basin; the Boy's gunshot heard not seen; the Mother's discovery physical with the veil never lifting; "the silence after the shot is the loudest thing in the play. Let nobody push." Name the Manager's pivot: he "sets the Boy-chair behind the fountain himself — the moment he stops being audience and becomes accessory." The closing exit is the audience's own; the last line "is not a punchline."

20:05

Second break (5 min)

Short scheduled breather across the most emotionally charged sit of the block. Rest the voice.

20:10

Talked-through agreement of the contact moments

Sit with the protocol's actual contact inventory (Context pillar), words only: name each Act Three choreographed contact — the Father/Son held grip, mutual, hands on shoulders, no shaking, no face proximity (line 148) — and recap the earlier moments (the veil, the chin, the shop-scene limit and screen, the 'Cry out, mother!' beat). Confirm each will be set as binding choreography in August, third party present, routed through the protocol — never improvised. Agree the gunshot and the Child's drowning are object-handling "as object, not as person" (line 122) — heavy, careful staging, not actor-intimacy. Confirm consent lives with the receiving actor and is revocable (lines 207/231); the back room is reported, never staged (line 114). Reaffirm 'Bounded bodies, unbounded moral force.' No staging, no physical work.

20:40

Round-robin and close

Each actor — including the Mother, the Son and the Players — names their Act Three super-objective in one line; de-role check-out; set homework; confirm next Thursday is the whole play integrated (relationships, metatheatre, tempo, comedy and safety — words only, never staged).

EXERCISES AT THE TABLE

The two-pass read of the Act Three spine (feeling vs. philosophy diagnostic)

On a selected span (the philosophy duel, the refusal and mirror speech, the fountain and the two deaths), not the whole act. PASS ONE neutral: read the spine flat, words and facts only; the room gives the act's OWN quiet its air even when uninflected — the Son's cry on 'horrible,' the silence after the gunshot, the fountain narration. Debrief 1: the facts and the logic of the duel. PASS TWO exaggerated: read it deliberately too big, overshooting BOTH raw feeling and cold philosophical detachment. Debrief 2: with both poles overshoot, locate the live line between them — where the Father is panic not paragraphs, where feeling lives against the argument — and re-confirm what stays protected and silent. State the truthful middle is found in August.

YIELDS The neutral pass surfaces the duel's logic and shields the act's own quiet keystones (the cry on 'horrible,' the silence after the shot, the fountain); the exaggerated pass is the diagnostic for THIS act — by overshooting both feeling and philosophy the company finds the live line the production runs on. Anchored to genuinely Act-Three material; the Mother's fragile lines and "It's taking place now" are Act One and Act Two lines and are protected in Sessions 1 and 2, since each session reads only its own act. Working the spine keeps it inside ~55 min, reconciled with Session 5's single-act read time. Anti-line-reading + exaggeration-to-find-range, on the play's coldest and rawest material.

Scoring the four-stage arc

The Father reads Part I while the room marks the exact lines where he moves control → injury → attack → horror; action each section with a verb that escalates in desperation. The Step-Daughter's three cuts are placed against those rungs and timed, with the rupture-tempi marked around the climaxes. Seated throughout.

YIELDS Turns the edition's signature Father arc and the Step-Daughter's cuts into a shared, timed structure of collision — "the point is made in his panic, not his paragraphs" — and builds tempo at the table, not on the last night.

The mirror-speech surprise read

The Son reads the mirror speech twice: once trying to 'arrive' at the feeling early (to feel why that fails), then finding the cry only on the word 'horrible.' The room watches for the door-closing flatness on either side.

YIELDS Embodies the note that the cry must surprise him mid-thought and be re-buried after (lines 3608–3609); guards against result-direction and pre-loaded emotion.

QUESTIONS TO PUT TO THE ROOM

- *After the exaggerated pass: when you overshoot both raw feeling and cold philosophy, where did the live line between them turn out to be — and where is the Father panicking rather than lecturing?*
- *Did the act's own quiet survive even the flat and the over-the-top passes — the Son's cry on 'horrible,' the silence after the gunshot, the fountain narration? What keeps each from being rolled over?*
- *Where does the Father 'walk into the wall' of his own philosophy, and how do the Step-Daughter's three cuts push him there?*
- *The Son 'agrees with the author who abandoned them.' Why does that make him the most modern, and most dangerous, figure?*
- *For the choreographed-contact moments: what is the report or the staging that carries the weight, so the bodies don't have to, and how do we handle the Boy-chair and Child-bundle as objects, not bodies? What must we agree now so August feels safe?*

HOMEWORK

Father: bring your four-stage arc fully actioned, escalating not repeating, and the live line your two passes found. Step-Daughter: fix the timing of your three cuts. Son: live with the mirror speech so the cry lands on 'horrible'; learn the fountain narration as one continuous sentence. Mother: decide the physical shape of your discovery with the veil never lifting and both children held. Manager: sit with the Boy-chair pivot — what makes you place that chair yourself. Everyone: note any personal response to the charged material and raise it privately if you wish (intake channel open). Keep driving toward the 20 August Act One off-book milestone.

BY THE END

By the end Act Three has been opened by the two-pass read of its spine (the exaggerated pass having located the live line between feeling and philosophy, the room having re-protected the act's own quiet — the cry on 'horrible,' the silence after the shot, the fountain), the Father's four-stage arc scored and actioned, the Step-Daughter's three cuts placed and timed with the rupture-tempi marked, the Son's refusal and his two wounds worked, the climax register agreed (stillness not volume; the silence after the shot protected), the Manager's Boy-chair pivot named, and a written, words-only agreement of the protocol's actual contact moments and their deferral to choreographed, consented August staging — with the gunshot and drowning understood as object work and the back room as reported, never staged. The evening stayed seated throughout.

The whole play integrated — relationships, orders of reality, tempo, comedy, and safety confirmed

The whole play worked integrated and in words only, never staged: relationships read across the full arc; the metatheatre / orders-of-reality applied throughout; tempo-rhythm mapped end to end against the gears built in Sessions 1–3; the nervous comedy and "Valentine" as a wounded provocation; and the charged-scene safety frameworks confirmed — every choreographed-contact moment talked through and confirmed as deferred to the 20 August staging block per the signed protocol. This evening deliberately substitutes the edition's 23 July Light & Sound walk-through (line 1798) with integrated, words-only table work; the full cue list is instead walked end-to-end in Session 5's cued read. No reading-into-action, no touch.

GOALS FOR THE EVENING

- Read relationships across the whole arc as one connected system — the Father explains / the Step-Daughter exposes / the Son refuses / the Mother carries — so each through-line is felt continuously, not act by act.
- Apply the metatheatre and orders of reality throughout: re-place every performer in their layer (Actors-playing-Actors; the Manager who plays a director first; the six fixed Characters; Madame Pace the conjured seventh, one of the nine) and track the collisions where 'who is more real' flips across the whole play.
- Map tempo-rhythm end to end against the gears built in Sessions 1–3 — company looseness vs. the Father/Step-Daughter drive; procedural brisk vs. exposed solo vs. airless apparition; the rupture-tempi around the two climaxes — confirming them so Session 5's cued read verifies tempo rather than discovers it.
- Confirm the nervous-not-punchline comedy company-wide, with Player 1's '[quiet now, almost ashamed; not a punchline]' (line 2332) — which falls in ACT ONE just before the Father's 'pity' speech (line 2334) — as the model, and "Valentine" (an Act One moment) as a wounded provocation, not a number.
- Confirm the charged-scene safety frameworks in words only: walk the protocol's full contact inventory (lines 132–148), reaffirm that every one is choreographed-and-consented in August (third party present), that the back room is reported never staged and the gunshot/drowning are object work, and that consent/veto are revocable (lines 207/231; 122) — talked through, never staged; and note this evening substitutes the master schedule's L&S walk-through, whose cue list is walked in Session 5.

THE EVENING, HOUR BY HOUR

18:00

Check-in, warm-up, objects in place

One-sentence check-in; seated vocal/breath warm-up. Step-Daughter and Mother take up the objects. The director frames tonight: the whole play held in one room, in words — relationships, layers, tempo, comedy and safety — with no staging at all, and names that tonight substitutes the master schedule's 23 July L&S walk-through, whose cue list is walked in Session 5.

18:15

Relationships across the whole arc

Read or trace each through-line continuously across all three acts: the Father explaining the wound, the Step-Daughter exposing it, the Son refusing it, the Mother carrying it. Where does each relationship turn across the arc — Father/Step-Daughter, Father/Son, Mother/Son, Mother/Step-Daughter? Note where a relationship read clearly in a single act but risks getting rolled over when the whole play runs.

18:50

Orders of reality, applied throughout

Re-place every performer in their layer (Actors-playing-Actors; the Manager who plays a director first, line

1601; the six fixed Characters; Madame Pace the conjured seventh, line 1665, one of the nine). Track the ontological collisions where 'who is more real' flips — the casting scene's failure of representation, the apparition, 'It's taking place now' (Act Two), the two deaths (Act Three). The architecture is the meaning; confirm each actor can name their layer's pressure at every collision.

19:10

Break (15 min)

Rest the voice; water and food.

19:25

Tempo-rhythm mapped end to end

Walk the whole play's tempo gears in sequence against what Sessions 1–3 marked: Act One's company looseness vs. the Father/Step-Daughter drive; Act Two's procedural brisk vs. exposed solo vs. airless apparition (and the vamp's mid-bar death); Act Three's rupture-tempi around the two climaxes and the protected silence after the shot. Confirm the gears so Session 5 verifies, not discovers, tempo. No result-direction — tempo is read as collision and interruption, not as 'faster/slower'.

19:55

The nervous comedy and "Valentine"

Confirm the register company-wide using Player 1's '[quiet now, almost ashamed; not a punchline]' (line 2332), which falls in ACT ONE just before the Father's 'pity' speech (line 2334), as the model line. Walk the comic beats across the whole play and agree where each laugh must curdle from avvertimento to sentimento. "Valentine" — an Act One moment — confirmed as 'a provocation from a wound' (line 1556), not a number: "if it plays as a merely funny number, the danger underneath it has been lost."

20:05

Second break (5 min)

Short scheduled breather. Rest the voice.

20:10

Safety frameworks confirmed — words only

Walk the protocol's full contact inventory in words (lines 132–148): the 'My passion, sir!' hand-on-shoulder; the veil-lift (Mother controls speed, holds veto, line 134); Madame Pace's hand under the chin; the shop-scene six-inch limit and screen disappearance; the 'Cry out, mother!' beat (line 144); the Mother separating them; the Father/Son grip (line 148). Confirm each is choreographed-and-consented in August, third party present, never improvised; the back room reported never staged (line 114); the gunshot/drowning object work "as object, not as person" (line 122). Reaffirm consent lives with the receiving actor and is revocable, including in performance (lines 207/231; absolute veto, line 122), and the company's own time-out word, check-in and de-role. Reaffirm 'Bounded bodies, unbounded moral force.' Talked through, never staged.

20:40

Round-robin and close

Each actor — including the Mother, the Son and the Players — names one thing about their character's WHOLE-PLAY arc and one thing they need from the floor to do it safely; de-role check-out; set homework; confirm next Thursday is the cue-called integrated read and the hand-off to August.

EXERCISES AT THE TABLE

Through-line trace across the whole play

Take each principal relationship (Father/Step-Daughter, Father/Son, Mother/Son, Mother/Step-Daughter) and read or summarise its key beats in order across all three acts in one continuous pass, marking where it turns and where, in the whole-play flow, it risks being rolled over by louder energy. Seated, words only.

YIELDS

Lets the company feel each relationship as one continuous system rather than three separate act-readings, so Session 5's run and the August floor build on connected through-lines (Stanislavski's through-line; Mitchell's relationships).

Name-your-layer-at-every-collision

Going round the table at each major ontological collision (casting scene, apparition, 'It's taking place now' in Act Two, the two deaths in Act Three), each performer states their layer and the pressure it is under at that exact moment — Actor-playing-Actor / Manager-as-tired-director / fixed Character / Madame Pace the conjured seventh. Words only.

YIELDS Makes the metatheatrical operative across the whole play (not just named on day one); the layer you inhabit governs every collision, and 'who is more real' is the play's engine (the edition's seven-Character count, lines 1601, 1665).

The contact-inventory walk-through (confirm, never stage)

Seated circle: walk the protocol's full contact inventory (lines 132–148) in order, each performer confirming the function of the moment that touches them and that it is deferred to consented August choreography with a third party present. Reaffirm the back room as reported, the gunshot/drowning as object work, and revocable consent. No reading-into-action, no touch.

YIELDS Confirms shared, spoken ownership of every charged moment's safe handling before the cued read and the floor (IDC Context/Consent; protocol lines 132–148, 201, 207/231), tracking the protocol's real inventory, not an invented triad — and stands in for the master schedule's 23 July L&S walk-through, whose cue list is instead walked in Session 5.

QUESTIONS TO PUT TO THE ROOM

- *Read whole, did each through-line — the Father explaining, the Step-Daughter exposing, the Son refusing, the Mother carrying — stay continuous, or did one get rolled over when the play ran end to end?*
- *At which collisions does 'who is more real' flip across the whole play, and can each of you name your layer's pressure at that exact moment?*
- *Where did the tempo flatten into one mid-tempo across the arc, and where did the collisions we marked in the act sessions still land as real ruptures?*
- *Did the comedy stay 'nervous, not a punchline' all the way through, and does "Valentine" (Act One) read as a wounded provocation rather than a number?*
- *Walking the contact inventory: is our safety agreement strong enough to carry every one of these into consented August choreography — and what does each of you still need to feel safe?*

HOMEWORK Re-read your whole part against tonight's relationship, layer and tempo notes, holding your through-line as one continuous line across all three acts. Bring any remaining questions about the charged scenes to the dedicated, choreographed August sessions — not to the floor unprepared (intake channel open meanwhile). Confirm you can name your layer at each major collision. Keep driving toward the 20 August Act One off-book milestone, progressive thereafter.

BY THE END By the end the company has held the whole play in one room in words: each through-line traced continuously across the arc; every performer re-placed in their layer and able to name its pressure at each collision; the tempo-rhythm gears confirmed end to end against Sessions 1–3; the nervous-not-punchline comedy and "Valentine" (Act One) as a wounded provocation confirmed company-wide; and the charged-scene safety frameworks confirmed in words — the protocol's full contact inventory walked, the back room understood as reported, the gunshot/drowning as object work, consent/veto reaffirmed, and every physical/intimacy moment confirmed as deferred to the 20 August staging block. This evening deliberately substituted the master schedule's L&S walk-through with integrated table work; the cue list is walked in Session 5. Nothing was staged.

The cue-called integrated read — and the hand-off to the floor

A full integrated CUED READ of the whole play with the SM calling cues aloud and the pianist marking tempo — Act Two given equal time to Acts One and Three — to feel relationships, scored cues and tempo-rhythm end to end as one continuous experience, confirming what Sessions 1–4 built and standing in for the master schedule's 23 July L&S walk-through by walking the full cue list here; then a clean hand-off to the 20 August staging block. A short voice-rest is inserted between Act One and Act Two so no continuous read crosses the 80-minute line. Close-out business is kept light, and front-loaded, so the read can be a true full read.

GOALS FOR THE EVENING

- Run the whole play end to end as one integrated, cue-called read — the SM calling every Light & Sound cue aloud from the prompt book, the pianist marking musical cues by tempo — giving Act Two as much time as Acts One and Three (~40 min each), so the company feels the tempo gears, scored cues and collisions across all three acts as one experience, with the full cue list walked here in lieu of the dropped 23 July L&S walk-through.
- Confirm, in the full run, the nervous-not-punchline comedy register (Player 1's Act One model line, line 2332, just before the Father's 'pity' speech, line 2334) and "Valentine" (Act One) as a wounded provocation — verifying the register built in Sessions 1 and 4.
- Hear relationships and through-lines land across the whole arc with the cues in place — the Father explains / the Step-Daughter exposes / the Son refuses / the Mother carries — and confirm the tempo-rhythm gears verified in Session 4 hold under a cued run.
- Re-confirm the safety frameworks before the floor — the company's time-out word, check-in/de-role, consent and veto (lines 207/231; absolute veto, line 122), and that every choreographed-contact moment is choreographed-and-consented in August — kept brief and front-loaded so it does not eat the read.
- Hand off cleanly to the 20 August staging block: confirm the staging calendar (20 Aug–1 Nov; summer break 5 & 13 Aug) and the off-book milestone (Act One off-book by 20 August, progressive thereafter).

THE EVENING, HOUR BY HOUR

18:00

Check-in, warm-up, frameworks read-back, objects in place

Check-in; seated warm-up. Step-Daughter and Mother take up the objects; pianist on hand to mark musical cues by tempo. Move close-out business UP front so the read is unbroken later: a brief frameworks read-back (each person restates one provision of the company's Room & Safety Agreement and the deferral of the protocol's contact moments to August) and a one-line hand-off note on the August calendar. Kept to ~15 min.

18:15

Integrated read — Act One, with cues

Full company reads Act One straight through (~40 min), seated, SM calling Light & Sound cues aloud (white → amber → red; the wing radio; "Valentine" sung or marked; the absence of sound into Act Two). Hold the tempo gears: company looseness against the Father/Step-Daughter drive. "Valentine" read as 'a provocation from a wound' — earn the laugh, then let it curdle. Confirm the nervous-not-punchline register on Player 1's '[quiet now, almost ashamed; not a punchline]' (line 2332), the Act One model line just before the Father's 'pity' speech.

18:55

Voice-rest between acts (10 min)

A short scheduled voice-rest after the unbroken Act One read, BEFORE Act Two, so no continuous reading crosses the 80-minute line (Act One alone runs from 18:15). Water, throat rest, no talk required. This honours the plan's own 80-minute / voice-rest rule on the most vocally sustained evening of the block.

19:05

Integrated read — Act Two, with cues (full time)

Read Act Two straight through with EQUAL time to the other acts (~40 min), SM calling cues (the shower; Satie; the Weimar vamp and its mid-bar death; the held chord); pianist marks the music by tempo. Keep the procedural brisk so the opening monologue, the apparition and the Mother's cry land against it. Feel the act's full tempo gears — the cue-dense centre of the play gets the time it needs, not 15 minutes.

19:45

Break (15 min)

Rest the voice; water and food.

20:00

Integrated read — Act Three, with cues

Read Act Three straight through (~30 min), SM calling cues (cello drone; the single sharp piano note; water sound; the gunshot in real silence; Spiegel im Spiegel as the lights go). Protect the silence after the shot — 'let nobody push.' Let the Manager's exit and the last line land without irony. A 2-minute breather mid-act if the voice tires.

20:30

Tempo-rhythm and relationships notes

Director gives brief, actionable, motivation-based notes on the whole arc: where tempo flattened, where a collision needs sharpening, where a relationship through-line read clearly or got rolled over — confirming the tempo gears verified in Session 4. No result-direction.

20:50

De-role close, hand-off, and thank-you

Final de-role check-out for the round of readings; the SM confirms the staging calendar (20 Aug–1 Nov; summer break 5 & 13 Aug) and the off-book milestone (Act One off-book by 20 August, progressive thereafter); the director sets the 20 August arrival expectation and thanks the company, closing the table-work block. (Detailed logistics already covered in the front-loaded read-back, so this stays short.)

EXERCISES AT THE TABLE

Cue-called integrated read, acts equally weighted

Read the whole play seated in one sitting (with the mid-evening break and a short inter-act voice-rest) while the SM calls every Light & Sound cue aloud from the prompt book and the pianist marks musical cues by tempo, giving Act Two the same ~40 minutes as Acts One and Three. No stopping for line fixes; notes are saved for after the read.

YIELDS Lets the company feel tempo-rhythm, the collisions and the scored cues as one continuous experience — the closest a table read gets to the shape of the show — without starving the cue-dense Act Two, which is the centre of the play. Verifies, not discovers, the tempo built across Sessions 1–4, and walks the full cue list in lieu of the dropped 23 July L&S walk-through. This is the one whole-act exposure the act-session two-passes deliberately reserved for tonight.

The 'Valentine' curdle in context

Run the Valentine turn inside the full Act One read (sung or marked), with the room having just heard she is 'two months orphaned and lately for sale'; the company notes the exact moment the laugh should curdle from avvertimento to sentimento. (Valentine is read here in its true Act One position, confirming the work done in Session 1.)

YIELDS Confirms Valentine as 'a wounded provocation' not a comic number (line 1556) — "if it plays as a merely funny number, the danger underneath it has been lost" — under the full cued run.

Frameworks read-back (front-loaded)

At the top of the evening, going round the table, each person reads or restates one provision of the company's Room & Safety Agreement and the deferral of all choreographed-contact work to consented August sessions. Kept brief so the integrated read runs unbroken later.

YIELDS Confirms shared, spoken ownership of the safety frameworks before the floor (IDC/O'Brien: agreed and rehearsed before they are ever needed), without stealing time from the read.

QUESTIONS TO PUT TO THE ROOM

- *Across the whole cued run, where did the tempo flatten into one mid-tempo — and where did the collisions land as real ruptures, as we marked them in the act sessions and Session 4?*
- *Did the comedy stay 'nervous, not a punchline' all the way through — turning from avvertimento to sentimento? Where did it tip toward farce?*
- *With the cues in place, did the Mother's silences and fragile lines — placed in Acts One and Two — survive the louder energy when we ran it whole?*
- *What does each of us most need from the August floor to do this safely and well — and is our safety agreement strong enough to carry it?*

HOMEWORK Have Act One off-book by 20 August (the floor's first day); memorise the rest progressively across the staging block and sit with your part-notes over the summer break; arrive on 20 August ready to be on your feet. Re-read your scenes against tonight's tempo and relationship notes. Bring any remaining questions for the charged scenes to the dedicated, choreographed August sessions — not to the floor unprepared. Note the summer-break dates (5 & 13 August) and the staging calendar (20 Aug–1 Nov).

BY THE END By the end you have read the whole play through once as an integrated, cue-called run with Act Two given its full weight and a voice-rest protecting the most vocally sustained evening; felt the tempo-rhythm, collisions and scored cues end to end (confirming what Sessions 1–4 built and walking the full cue list in lieu of the dropped L&S walk-through); confirmed the nervous-not-punchline comedy and "Valentine" (Act One) as a wounded provocation under a cued run; re-confirmed the safety frameworks (time-out, check-in/de-role, consent/veto, the protocol's contact moments choreographed-and-consented in August); and handed off to the 20 August staging block with the calendar set, the Act One off-book milestone clear, and the round of readings complete.

Traps to avoid

- Skipping or softening the neutral pass. The temptation is to "get on with it" and read with feeling straight away — but the flat pass is the load-bearing one: it surfaces structure and facts and, above all, stops actors locking premature line-readings. Protect it. If actors keep colouring it, drop to the fast "Italian run" variant to defeat inflection.
- Mistaking the exaggerated pass for the performance. Over-the-top is a diagnostic, not the goal; sustained exaggeration is result-acting / indicating — an emotion pushed rather than discovered. Name it as an experiment, run it once, debrief it, and DO NOT try to carry the size forward. The truthful middle is found in August, on the floor, by keeping the freedom and discoveries and losing the scale, reconnected to action and target.
- Trying to two-pass the WHOLE act in the time given. The two passes plus two debriefs run on the act's SPINE SCENES — a selected span — not the entire act; a flat pass and an over-the-top pass of a full act plus debriefs would run 80+ minutes (cf. Session 5's ~40 min for a single straight cued read of one act) and would either

overflow or silently truncate the act, defeating the purpose. Pick the spine deliberately, name it, and leave the whole-act hearing to Session 5's cued read.

- Directing from page one. The strongest repeated warning in the practitioner literature: do not stop-start to fix line readings or deliver interpretation before the actors have offered their own instinct. Read first, talk second. Run the two passes and ASK the room what each revealed before offering any reading of your own.
- Letting the comedy win — stopping at the *avvertimento*. A cast leans into the genuinely funny interruptions, the Manager's vanity, Madame Pace's accent — and the laugh never curdles, so the Step-Daughter's near-prostitution, the drowning and the suicide stay gags (the *avvertimento* with no *sentimento*). Equally fatal is playing it as cold relativism with no laugh at all. Use the Act Two exaggerated pass precisely to expose why the comedy after Madame Pace must be NERVOUS, not funny-show, and the Act One exaggerated pass to test "Valentine" as a wound; police the *umorismo* every session.
- Over-intellectualising / table work that never ends. Five evenings is deliberately tight. Every over-talked minute is an August staging minute lost. When talk stops earning its keep, stop talking; the discoveries that matter are made on the floor.
- Locking choices too early — director or actor. Setting a character "take" or a line reading in stone at the table "stifles golden new choices." The edition's readings are "starting points, not commands" (line 1519); the table tests them, and the neutral pass is built to keep them open.
- Swallowing the quiet roles. A round-robin in EVERY session and Hagen homework are built so every actor speaks: the Mother, the Son and the Players (including the curious Player 3 with the notebook) are asked the same questions as the Father and the Step-Daughter, and take a full part in the exaggerated pass. The Mother's fragile lines must never be rolled over by louder energy — including at full size in Pass Two, in the act where each actually falls (three in Act One, "My son —" in Act Two).
- Drifting toward staging or physical work at the table. Per the signed protocol the SEVEN Thursdays (18 June – 30 July, of which this plan works five) are "table work only... No blocking. No physical work" (*build_intimacy_protocol.py* line 179); the block's own governing principle is "table work, not blocking" (line 1803). The exaggerated pass scales voice and impulse only, never contact across the table. The choreographed-contact moments (protocol lines 132–148) are discussed in words and explicitly deferred to 20 August; the back-room transaction is discussed only as the reported event. The objects are present from 2 July but are handled as conventions, not blocked.
- Result direction ("be sad", "be louder", "get angry"). Reach the beat indirectly through action, target and circumstance. The edition models this: find the Son's cry "on the word horrible, not before" (line 3608); the Mother's outburst must "come out faster than her body can carry it" (line 2901) — never a played emotion. (The exaggerated pass is the one sanctioned exception, and only as a bounded diagnostic.)
- Flattening the tempo into a single mid-tempo. The play runs on interruption and collision, not flow — the loose comic naturalism of the company against the airless drive of the Father and Step-Daughter. Map the tempo gears INSIDE each act-session (Sessions 1–3) and across the integrated work (Session 4) so Session 5's cued read CONFIRMS tempo rather than discovering a problem with no table time left to fix it.
- Over-running the voice. The sessions are vocally heavy and the exaggerated pass pushes volume; rest the voice at the scheduled breaks (15-minute mid-evening, plus a 5-minute second break in the back half — and in Session 5 a short voice-rest between Act One and Act Two so no continuous read crosses 80 minutes) and don't push through fatigue. Empower anyone — SM or cast — to call a two-minute "hold" as well.
- Mistaking the director's or script's permission for consent, or treating the company's own de-role/time-out practices as optional niceties. Consent lives with the actor receiving the action and is revocable at any moment, including in performance (protocol signature, lines 207/231); the absolute veto sits with the Step-Daughter and

the Mother (line 122). The time-out word and check-out are practices the company writes for itself and agrees before they are needed.

- Mis-counting the charged material. There is no fixed "three charged events." Track the protocol's actual contact inventory (lines 132–148) — and remember the back room is reported, never staged, while the gunshot and drowning are object-handling, not intimacy work. The under-counted beat to watch is the "Cry out, mother!" contact (line 144), the most demanding actor-contact moment after the shop scene; name it explicitly in the Act Two session (Session 2).
- Mis-attributing a moment to the wrong act. Read against the act boundaries (Act I ends line 2574; Act II = 2578–3349; Act III = 3353+): "Valentine" is ACT ONE (the family arrives, line 1747), so it belongs to Session 1's work, not Session 2's; the keystone "It's taking place now" and the Mother's second silence are ACT TWO (line 3326), so they belong to Session 2, not Session 3; Act Three's quiet to protect is its own — the Son's cry on "horrible," his refusal, the silence after the gunshot, the fountain. A two-pass that protects or tests a line the act does not contain cannot do its job, because each session reads only its own act.

Where this comes from — further reading

- **Six Characters in Search of an Author — director's edition ([six_characters_village_players.html](#))** — Luigi Pirandello, adapted and directed by Kiarash Jamshidi (Storer translation, reworked). *The production's own master document. Source for every bespoke decision quoted in this plan: the Portraits gallery (the four-stage Father arc; the Mother as silent centre with her three silences, four fragile lines and the veil; the Step-Daughter as moral centre, 'the wit is rage', exposure not flirtation; the Son's refusal and mirror speech with the cry on 'horrible', lines 3607–3609; the Manager who 'plays a director first', line 1601, and his Boy-chair pivot; Madame Pace as the conjured seventh Character / her own performer, line 1665, one of the nine; 'Valentine' as a wounded provocation, line 1556, an ACT ONE moment sung as the family arrives, line 1747; Player 3's pronoun left to the director, line 1647); the part-narrative playing-notes (lines 1891, 1990, 2332/2334, 3133, 3566, 3607); the Light & Sound score (the pianist 'fourth Player, in effect', line 1752); 'It's taking place now' as the key to the production (line 3093) and the line itself in ACT TWO (line 3326, before Act III opens at 3353); the two stage objects; the three stripped settings; the nine-performer count (lines 1687–1691). The act boundaries used to keep each two-pass within its own act: Act I ends line 2574, Act II = 2578–3349, Act III = 3353+. Its master-schedule notes (the SEVEN Thursdays, 18 June–30 July, lines 1782–1803) inform the calendar; this plan deliberately compresses them into five July Thursdays, folds the dropped 18/25 June first-read and walk-through into Session 1, substitutes the 23 July L&S walk-through (line 1798) with Session 4's integrated table work and Session 5's cue-walk, keeps 16 July seated under 'table work, not blocking' (line 1803) rather than the looser 'on his feet' note (line 1796), and says where it adapts the edition's own notes.*
- **Intimacy and Consent Protocol ([scripts/build_intimacy_protocol.py](#))** — Kiarash Jamshidi / Village Players. *The signed standalone contract. Source for 'Bounded bodies, unbounded moral force' (line 201); 'the intensity is in the report, not the display' (line 125); the back room never staged, carried by the Step-Daughter's account (line 114); the absolute veto for the Step-Daughter and Mother (line 122); the gunshot/drowning handled 'as object, not as person' (line 122); the full contact inventory (lines 132–148: 'My passion, sir!' hand-on-shoulder; the veil-lift with the Mother controlling speed, line 134; Madame Pace's hand under the chin; the shop-scene six-inch limit and screen disappearance; the 'Cry out mother' beat, the most demanding after the shop scene, line 144; the Mother separating them; the Father/Son grip, line 148); revocability including in performance (signature, lines 207/231); and the scope rule that 'The SEVEN Thursdays are table work only ... No blocking. No physical work' (line 179) — this plan works five of those seven evenings. The protocol contains NO time-out word, check-in, de-role or intake channel — those are the production's own practices, not protocol clauses. All charged physical/intimacy work is deferred to the 20 August staging block.*

- **The two-pass read (neutral first, exaggerated second) — a verified composite, not a single branded method** — Synthesised from Mitchell, Donnellan, StageMilk/Casting Networks, Stanislavski/Knebel; assembled for this edition by Kiarash Jamshidi. *The director's signature opening exercise for each act, run on that act's SPINE SCENES (a selected span, not the whole act — so two passes plus two debriefs fit ~55 min, reconciled with Session 5's ~40 min for a single straight act-read; the whole-act exposure is reserved for Session 5's cued read). Honestly attributed as a composite: NO single canonical source packages 'neutral-then-exaggerated' under one name. Its verified lineages: Mitchell's neutral, fact-first table-work and use of neutral language so the actors are not pre-coloured (the rationale for Pass One); the well-attested anti-line-reading principle (Donnellan, *The Actor and the Target*; *Stareable*; *No Film School*) — a line reading produces copied delivery, not discovered behaviour; exaggeration-to-find-range and its failure mode, result-acting/indicating (StageMilk; Casting Networks); 'Same Lines, Different Meanings' (Theatrefolk) and the 'Italian run' speed read (opera origin) as cousins/variants; and the whole arc resting on Stanislavski/Knebel's Active Analysis — 'the best analysis of a play is to take action in the given circumstances.' Each act's pass is scoped to its own text — Valentine in Act One, the keystone in Act Two, the cry-on-horrible/fountain in Act Three — never to a line from another act. The truthful middle is found on the floor in August, not at the table.*
- **The Director's Craft: A Handbook for the Theatre** — Katie Mitchell (Routledge, 2009). *The director-led world-building spine: facts and questions, back-history, the world of the play / big ideas, immediate circumstances (the 24 hours before), neutrally-named events, and intentions ('pictures of the future that drive present action'). The use of neutral language so as not to pre-colour the actors is also the rationale behind the neutral pass of the two-pass read. Used to build the shared objective world before interpretation.*
- **Stanislavski's system and Active Analysis (units & objectives, super-objective, through-line)** — Konstantin Stanislavski; transmitted via Maria Knebel (Active Analysis; A Director's Guide to Stanislavsky's Active Analysis, ed. James Thomas) and Jane Baldwin's 'The Knebel technique'. *Source for units/objectives, super-objective and through-line; the caution that grounds this plan's tightness (late in his career Stanislavski distrusted long seated analysis for opening a gap between mental and physical work); and the principle underneath the two-pass read — 'the best analysis of a play is to take action in the given circumstances,' with Knebel's étude ladder from silence to the playwright's words. The substance is well-sourced; the popular 'twenty years' duration is not asserted. Hence we get up in August.*
- **Actioning; Actions: The Actors' Thesaurus; Different Every Night** — Max Stafford-Clark and Bill Gaskill (Joint Stock / later Out of Joint); Marina Caldarone & Maggie Lloyd-Williams (Nick Hern Books); Mike Alfreds, *Different Every Night* (Nick Hern Books). *The line-level engine: assign one transitive, playable, present-tense verb per thought, fitting 'I ___ you', introduced only after events/intentions are agreed. The technique emerged from the Joint Stock workshop process co-led by Stafford-Clark and Gaskill in the late 1970s, so the cast holds it as a company rehearsal-room method, not one director's invention. Alfreds restates the caution against over-fixing and frames the ensemble freedom the two-pass read drops into. Gives every line a recoverable, repeatable choice — vital for a semi-amateur company over a run.*
- **Respect for Acting / A Challenge for the Actor (the questions / six steps)** — Uta Hagen. *The actor's private prep checklist (Hagen preferred the later six steps): Who am I? / circumstances (especially 'what just happened') / relationships / what do I want? / obstacle / what do I do to get it? Dovetails with Mitchell's circumstances; used as homework so quiet roles prep as fully as leads.*
- **The Actor and the Target** — Declan Donnellan (Nick Hern Books, 2002/2005). *Keeps the work pointed outward: act toward a specific external target and what the character needs from it, rather than introspecting. 'You can never know what you are doing until you first know what you are doing it to.' Direct lines outward to a changing target, not into oneself — the antidote to indicated line-readings and the way the exaggerated pass is brought back toward truth (action and target, not pushed feeling). Redirects any 'I feel...' note into action.*
- **Impro: Improvisation and the Theatre (status work)** — Keith Johnstone (1979). *The lens for the company/ensemble scenes in Act Two: status is played not possessed, the see-saw 'I go up and you go down', and*

play-the-status read-throughs (a point higher, then lower, then alternating). Makes the vain/working/curious Players-and-Manager dynamics legible and tunable, seated.

- **L'Umoreismo (On Humor)** — Luigi Pirandello (1908). *The source of the register this production turns on, and the distinction that makes it teachable: the merely comic is the avvertimento del contrario (the bare perception of the opposite — you laugh); umorismo proper is the sentimento del contrario (the reflective feeling that reverses the laugh into pain). The edition's 'earn the laugh, then let it curdle' IS the move from avvertimento to sentimento — and the exaggerated pass of the two-pass read is the diagnostic that exposes, on Act One's 'Valentine' and on Act Two's casting scene and Madame Pace aria especially, why the comedy must be nervous, not funny-show.*
- **Practical guides to running the read-through and the table-work period** — Theatrefolk ('Having an Effective Table Read' and 'Same Lines, Different Meanings'); The Scene; Much Ado About Drama; Stareable and No Film School (on why early line readings lock premature interpretation); Erin Joy Swank (breaks); Equity break standards. *Source for the room logistics and the two-pass rationale: read for discovery not correction, don't direct from page one, read first/talk second, group work by relationship so no one sits idle, the prompt book in pencil with a key, a real break inside every 80 minutes (here honoured with a 15-minute mid-evening break PLUS a scheduled 5-minute second break in the charged back half, and in Session 5 a short inter-act voice-rest so no continuous read crosses 80 minutes), empowering the room to call breaks, and progressive off-book toward the floor. 'Same Lines, Different Meanings' is the classroom-scale cousin of the two-pass read (neutral, then through emotions, then debrief).*

This plan is a researched scaffold, not a script for the evenings. Sessions may run longer or shorter inside the 18:00–21:00 window depending on the room; the architecture is what matters — each Thursday lays one course of the wall the August staging block will build on.